

Where You Are Now

Forty-two sections in. What you have, and what to keep.

You started with a site and a vague sense that SEO was a list of tactics. You finish with a map of four disciplines, a capstone site that has been audited and rebuilt against every one of them, and a way of judging claims that outlives any specific tactic in this book.

What the capstone has

- **Foundations.** A keyword map built on intent, a first properly optimized page, and measurement wired up before any of the work began.
- **On-page.** Titles and metas rewritten, content restructured into clusters, internal linking deliberate, E-E-A-T demonstrated rather than claimed, and a prune-and-consolidate pass done.
- **Technical.** Crawlable, indexable, canonically clean, correctly redirected, sensibly structured, renderable without JavaScript, fast enough on mobile, and marked up with schema that matches what is visible.
- **Authority and AI.** A baselined link profile, reclaimed brand mentions, entity identity anchored in Wikidata and *sameAs*, a deliberate AI crawler policy, and citation share tracked across four answer engines.

The three things worth carrying

- 1 **Evidence tiers.** You now separate what Google confirmed from what a vendor asserted. Only seven ranking factors are confirmed. The corpus behind this book is 18 confirmed sources against 302 practitioner ones, and pretending otherwise is how bad advice spreads.
- 2 **Floors versus levers.** Core Web Vitals, mobile-friendliness and HTTPS are floors: failing suppresses you, exceeding buys nothing. Content, authority and topical coverage are levers. Most wasted SEO budget is someone optimizing a floor.
- 3 **Coverage beats optimization.** Query fan-out turns one prompt into ten to twenty searches, so comprehensive topical coverage catches what a single optimized page misses. 80%+ coverage retains 85.4% of AI visibility.

The honest summary of 2026

Informational click volume is structurally down and will not recover. Commercial intent is far more resilient. AI-referred traffic converts 4 to 5x better than traditional search. Ranking and being cited have come apart, so they are two reports now, not one. None of that means SEO is dead. It means the thing being optimized changed from a position to a selection.

The cadence from here

SEO has no finish line, it has a rhythm: **audit, fix, publish, measure, adjust**. Section 42's 90-day plan is one turn of it. Run the technical audit quarterly, refresh important content on the same schedule because Perplexity deprioritizes anything over 90 days, check citation share monthly, and keep an action log so the six-month lag before results is survivable.

When this book is wrong

It will be, in places, and sooner than you would like. Search is moving fast enough that specific numbers age in months. What should hold longer is the method: ask who measured a claim, whether it was causal or correlational, and whether the source sells the thing it is recommending. When a number here conflicts with something you can verify directly, trust what you can verify.

How this was built

Fourteen deep research passes through a multi-engine pipeline produced 399 raw sources, deduped to **320** and split across six notebooks. Every claim was synthesized with citations and tagged by evidence tier. Where sources disagreed, both numbers are shown rather than averaged. Where no evidence existed, the gap is stated instead of filled. The full cited synthesis lives in the skill at *references/research-synthesis.md*, and every [sN] marker there resolves to a real URL in *_research/sources.json*.

Now go and rank something.